

Draft. Nothing here has been discussed with Kilburn's businesses or organisations yet. This is a starting proposal for how that conversation could begin, written before it happens — not a report on engagement that's already taken place. Every organisation named below is named because it already exists and already does this work, not because it has agreed to be part of anything.

Working note, September 2026

A side exploration within the wider Camden work, 2026

One street, two boroughs, hundreds of independent businesses already doing the work.

Kilburn High Street isn't a blank site for a new food-system intervention. It's a working high street with its own market, its own growers, its own community kitchen, and a community-led partnership already trying to hold it together. The question this page starts to answer isn't "what should we build here" — it's "what's already here, and how does the wider portfolio's thinking actually help it."

[See the proposed approach](#)[Back to Food as Infrastructure](#)[Open the Hubs & Markets Working Group](#)

~400

Shops on Kilburn High Road, roughly three-quarters independent

2

Boroughs sharing one street — Camden on one side, Brent on the other

£12m+

Already committed to the street's public realm by both councils and TfL

0

Conversations with local businesses and organisations had so far — deliberately, this is where it starts

Not a Camden pilot site — a genuinely shared street

Why Kilburn High Street, specifically

Most of this portfolio's place-based work sits inside one borough at a time. Kilburn High Street can't — and that's exactly what makes it worth exploring.

Kilburn High Road is the boundary. Camden holds one side of the street, Brent holds the other, following the old line of Watling Street — so anything built to serve "Kilburn" has to work across a council line by definition, not as an ambitious extra step taken later. The two councils already know this: they've been working together on the street since 2021, and have jointly spent over £1.5m upgrading paving, lighting and street furniture in the upper section alone, with a further £8m from TfL and £4m of their own money now committed to widening pavements, adding protected cycle crossings and pocket parks through the heart of Kilburn.

More importantly, the street already has a working model of cross-boundary, community-led governance to plug into: **One Kilburn**, a Community Improvement District piloted by Camden with funding from Power to Change and the GLA. Unlike a conventional Business Improvement District, a CID is built to give residents and community organisations a say over the high street's direction alongside businesses — which is precisely the governance

shape a civic-led food-system effort needs, and precisely the kind of structure this portfolio has been arguing London boroughs should be building anyway.

There's also a live "Healthy Town Centre" consultation getting under way for the whole of Kilburn, and a cross-boundary Kilburn Neighbourhood Forum already drafting a Neighbourhood Plan covering both sides of the street. None of this needs to be invented. It needs to be found, understood, and asked whether food belongs inside it.

What's structurally different about this street

Boundary	Runs down the middle of the street itself, Camden / Brent
Existing partnership	One Kilburn Community Improvement District
Existing planning body	Kilburn Neighbourhood Forum, cross-boundary
Live consultation	Camden's Healthy Town Centre process for all of Kilburn
Funding route already open	Camden's Future High Streets Crowdfund, match-funded
Shop mix	~400 shops, roughly a quarter national chains

Building with what exists, not around it

What's already here, worth knowing before proposing anything

The instinct in this portfolio's other work has been to look for what's already operating before suggesting something new. Kilburn already has more than most streets.

Already growing, and already civic

Granville Community Kitchen's farm hub, South Kilburn

A community farm and kitchen explicitly built to belong to the people of South Kilburn, not to a landlord or a council department — the closest thing on this street to the "civic infrastructure" language the rest of this portfolio uses. Any food-system proposal for Kilburn should start by understanding what this organisation has already learned, not by proposing something that duplicates it.

Already trading, already independent

Kilburn Square Market and specialist independents

A working market at Kilburn Square alongside the high street itself, plus long-standing specialist independents — an independent fishmonger among them. This is the existing food economy any collective-buying or shortened-supply-chain thinking would need to serve, not compete with.

Coming soon, worth watching

Kilburn Community Garden, Kilburn Grange Park

A new community growing space planned for Kilburn Grange Park, alongside wider community-growing support from Brent, Camden and Groundwork London across the area. Another natural early conversation, and one that sits on the Camden side of the boundary already.

A signal worth reading correctly

Private capital is already moving into food here

A new 14-unit food court, Food District, is opening on Kilburn High Road — real evidence that commercial investors see food and hospitality as the street's growth story right now. That's not a threat to work around; it's

confirmation of the underlying premise elsewhere in this portfolio, that there's real money in food. The question worth asking is whether any of that momentum can be shaped to benefit the street's existing independent food economy, rather than only the new entrant.

Starting with listening, not a proposal

How we'd actually approach this

The rest of this portfolio's place-based pages report on conversations that have already happened. This one doesn't have that yet — so instead of manufacturing findings, here's the proposed order of operations.

First, join the structure that already exists. One Kilburn's whole purpose is giving local people and organisations a say over the street's direction — the honest first move is to understand how it works and ask whether food belongs on its agenda, rather than starting a parallel conversation.

Second, talk to the organisations already doing this work, on their terms. Granville Community Kitchen has real, lived experience of building food-related civic infrastructure in this exact place. The Kilburn Square Market traders and the street's independent food retailers understand the street's actual economics better than any outside proposal could. Listening to what they need — not what a portfolio framework assumes they need — comes before any design work.

Third, understand the two-borough mechanics properly. Camden and Brent have already built one working example of joint governance here (One Kilburn) and one joint planning process (the Neighbourhood Forum). Whatever

gets proposed needs to work inside that existing cross-boundary machinery, not require a new one.

Fourth, only then ask what's missing. Once the picture above is actually filled in — not assumed — it becomes possible to ask honestly whether Kilburn needs anything closer to a hub, a collective-buying arrangement, a school-food procurement link, or simply better-connected support for what already exists. That answer isn't known yet, deliberately.

Open questions, not yet answered

Governance	Does food belong on One Kilburn's own agenda, or does it need its own strand?
Duplication risk	What has Granville Community Kitchen already tried, and what did it learn?
Scale	Is this a street-level question, or does it only make sense at South Kilburn / whole-Kilburn scale?
Two councils	Which side of the boundary, if either, actually needs to hold any new investment?
The new food court	Ally, ignore, or engage — not yet decided

Where this sits

How this connects to the wider work

Kilburn isn't a detour from the rest of this portfolio — it's the same questions, at street scale, with the cross-borough problem already built into the geography.

Portfolio ambition

A coalition of boroughs, tested at street level

The portfolio's wider "coalition of boroughs" thinking usually means Camden's neighbours coordinating rather than repeating work from zero. Kilburn forces that same coordination at a much smaller scale — a single street where it isn't optional.

[See the Supply / Hub / Demand portfolio](#)

Working group

The Hubs & Markets Working Group's own findings apply directly

The working group has already found that hub failure risk sits in operating skillset, not good intentions, and that space economics need to be stated plainly, early. Both apply directly here, if a hub-shaped idea ever gets proposed for Kilburn.

[Read the working group's findings](#)

Economic framing

The same "fat middle" argument, at high-street scale

The portfolio's economic case elsewhere is about shortening the distance between growers and the people who cook — cutting out an inefficient, expensive middle. Kilburn's own independent food retailers already sit at exactly that point in the chain.

[See the local-level instruments](#)

Honest, not aspirational

What's next

No commitments have been made to anyone named on this page. These are the concrete first steps for finding out whether there's something worth building together.

First moves Before any proposal takes shape

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| 01 | Find out how to engage with One Kilburn directly, and understand what's already on its agenda. | Open |
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| 02 | Have a first, listening-only conversation with Granville Community Kitchen about what they've already tried and what they'd want help with, if anything. | Open |
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| 03 | Talk to a handful of Kilburn Square Market and high street independent food traders directly, rather than assuming their needs from outside. | Open |
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| 04 | Read the Kilburn Neighbourhood Plan and the Healthy Town Centre consultation material in full, to see whether food is already on the table or genuinely missing. | Open |
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| 05 | Only after 01–04: decide whether this becomes its own strand of work, folds into an existing Camden or borough effort, or turns out not to need anything new at all. | Not yet due |
|----|--|-----------------------------|

The point of this page: to have somewhere honest to start from — what's already true about this street, what already exists to build with, and what

hasn't been asked yet. Nothing here is a commitment on behalf of Camden, Brent, or anyone named above.

Sources

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Kilburn High Street

A starting proposal for a specific stretch of Camden and Brent, part of Dark Matter Labs' Food as Infrastructure portfolio.

This page

- Why here
- What's already here
- How we'd approach it
- What's next

Wider portfolio

Hubs & Markets Working Group

Food as Infrastructure

A Sovereign Food System

This page draws only on publicly available information about Kilburn High Street, listed in Sources above — no organisation named on this page has been contacted yet, and nothing here should be read as representing their views.

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